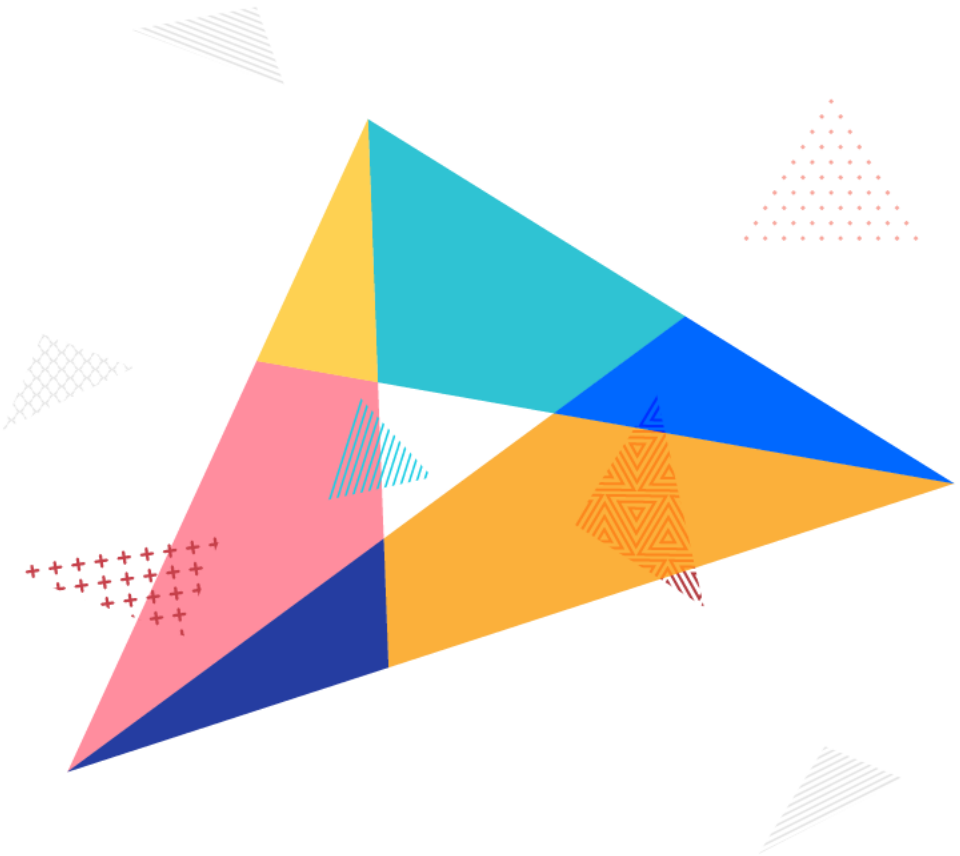
RMIT UNIVERSITY

Zalo

me.grow

RMIT University Vietnam, Saigon South Campus



Solve Tech & Organisational Blockers

An AI-augmented, human-centred problem-solving lab for first-line managers

Dr. Thuan Nguyen & Dr. Bidyut Hazarika

Understand people | **Frame the problem** | **Expand with AI** | **Prototype fast** | **Test & decide**

WHERE THIS SESSION FITS

This session bridges leadership behaviour and later capstone workplace application.

Before today	Today	After today
Leadership transition Performance conversations Delegation & accountability Influence across teams	Solve tech and organisational blockers through human-centred thinking, AI augmentation and practical action.	Operational bottlenecks Strategic thinking Business cases Capstone application

Link to Zalo competencies: Solve Complex Problems + Drive Impact

TODAY'S OUTCOMES

Participants leave with a tested way of thinking, clear AI guardrails and a concrete next step.

Stakeholder insight: Understand who is affected, what they need and what constraints they face.

Problem framing: Turn symptoms and assumptions into an evidence-based problem statement.

Solution options: Generate human ideas first, then use AI to expand perspectives and challenge blind spots.

Prototype + feedback: Create a low-cost intervention; use AI to accelerate where useful, then test with real people.

Action decision (if we have time): Use human judgement to resolve, collaborate, pilot or escalate with a clear recommendation.

Main outputs

1. One Design Thinking Blocker Canvas
2. One AI-challenged option set
3. One prototype or workplace experiment
4. One escalation-ready recommendation
5. One 7-day action commitment

HOW WE WILL WORK TODAY

The quality of the session depends on YOU

1. Work in table groups

Stay with the same group for the full case so each activity builds on the last.

2. Take rotating roles

Assign a facilitator, evidence keeper, stakeholder advocate, prototype builder and spokesperson.

3. Make thinking visible

Use the canvas, sticky notes and group outputs. Avoid discussion that stays only in the air.

4. Challenge as a team

Ask: what evidence supports this, who is affected, what are we assuming, and is AI adding value or noise?

5. Produce group output

Each activity ends with a visible table output that can be shared, tested or improved.

AI can be a part of this problem-solving process too.

THREE-HOUR
INTERACTIVE FLOW

Designed for 1:30 PM–4:30 PM with one 15-minute break.

1:30–1:45	**Open + group formation**	Form table groups, select roles and choose one anonymised blocker.
1:45–2:05	**Framework + AI**	Use human-centred design thinking with AI as a selective thinking partner.
2:05–2:30	**Case + group empathy**	Map one stakeholder perspective. Human empathy first; no invented AI personas.
2:30–3:00	**Define + reframe**	Separate evidence from assumptions; write a problem statement
3:00–3:15	**Break**	Reset.
3:15–3:35	**Human + AI ideation**	Generate human ideas first, then use approved AI to expand missed perspectives.
3:35–4:00	**Prioritize + prototype**	Humans choose; AI may accelerate a rough process, template or experiment.
4:00–4:20	**Peer test + escalation**	Real people test the prototype; groups revise and practise escalation.
4:20–4:30	**Workplace transfer** (If we have time)	Turn learning into a safe, owned 7-day workplace action.

Main outputs: stakeholder insight → problem framing → human ideas → AI expansion → human decision → prototype → real feedback → action

ACTIVITY 1

BLOCKER PULSE/ PROBLEM

Select one real blocker that your group will work with. Start from lived experience

Table groups | 10 minutes

1. Share options	2. Select one blocker	3. Assumed solution
Each member shares one blocker/problem: what is happening, who is affected, and what outcome is at risk.	Choose the blocker that is most useful for practice: relevant to Zalo, cross-functional and realistic	(Optional) capture the assumed solution people are already jumping to.

Group output: one selected problem/blocker, and one assumed solution to challenge later.

AUTHENTIC CASE

Example Problem/Blocker

Example:

A cross-functional team is preparing to launch a new major of Business program. The major is now two weeks behind schedule.

- Marketing team says students' need changed.
- Program manager says complexity was underestimated.
- Lecturers says that they were involved too late.
- Quality control team finds multiple policies need to follow.

→ *Meetings increase but progress does not improve. Senior management expects the original launch date.*

The goal is not to find answers. The goal is to practise a better process for **framing and diagnosing the problem**

Case snapshot: A cross-functional team is preparing to launch a new digital feature before an important customer campaign. The feature is now two weeks behind schedule.

- Product says requirements changed.
- Engineering says complexity was underestimated.
- Data says it was involved too late.
- QA finds repeated defects.

→ *Meetings increase but progress does not improve. Senior management expects the original launch date.*

What makes it realistic?

- Technical and organisational causes are mixed
- Stakeholders see the blocker differently
- There are trade-offs between date, scope and quality
- Decision authority is unclear
- The first solution may not address the real problem

ACTIVITY 1

BLOCKER PULSE/ PROBLEM

Select one real blocker that your group will work with. Start from lived experience

Table groups | 10 minutes

1. Share options	2. Select one blocker	3. Assumed solution
Each member shares one blocker/problem: what is happening, who is affected, and what outcome is at risk.	Choose the blocker that is most useful for practice: relevant to Zalo, cross-functional and realistic	(Optional) capture the assumed solution people are already jumping to.

Group output: one selected problem/blocker, and one assumed solution to challenge later.

How can we frame a problem



Practice has many problems and most of these problems are difficult to solve

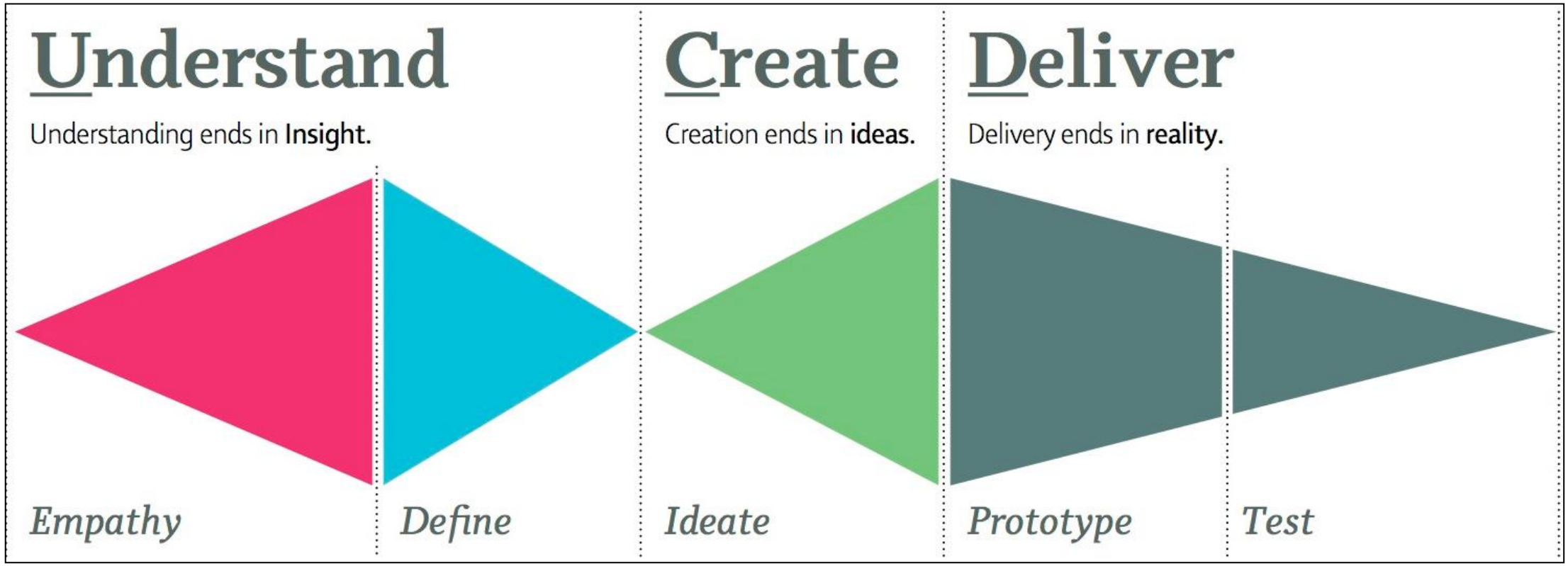


When we combine this with cross-team operations, it becomes even more difficult

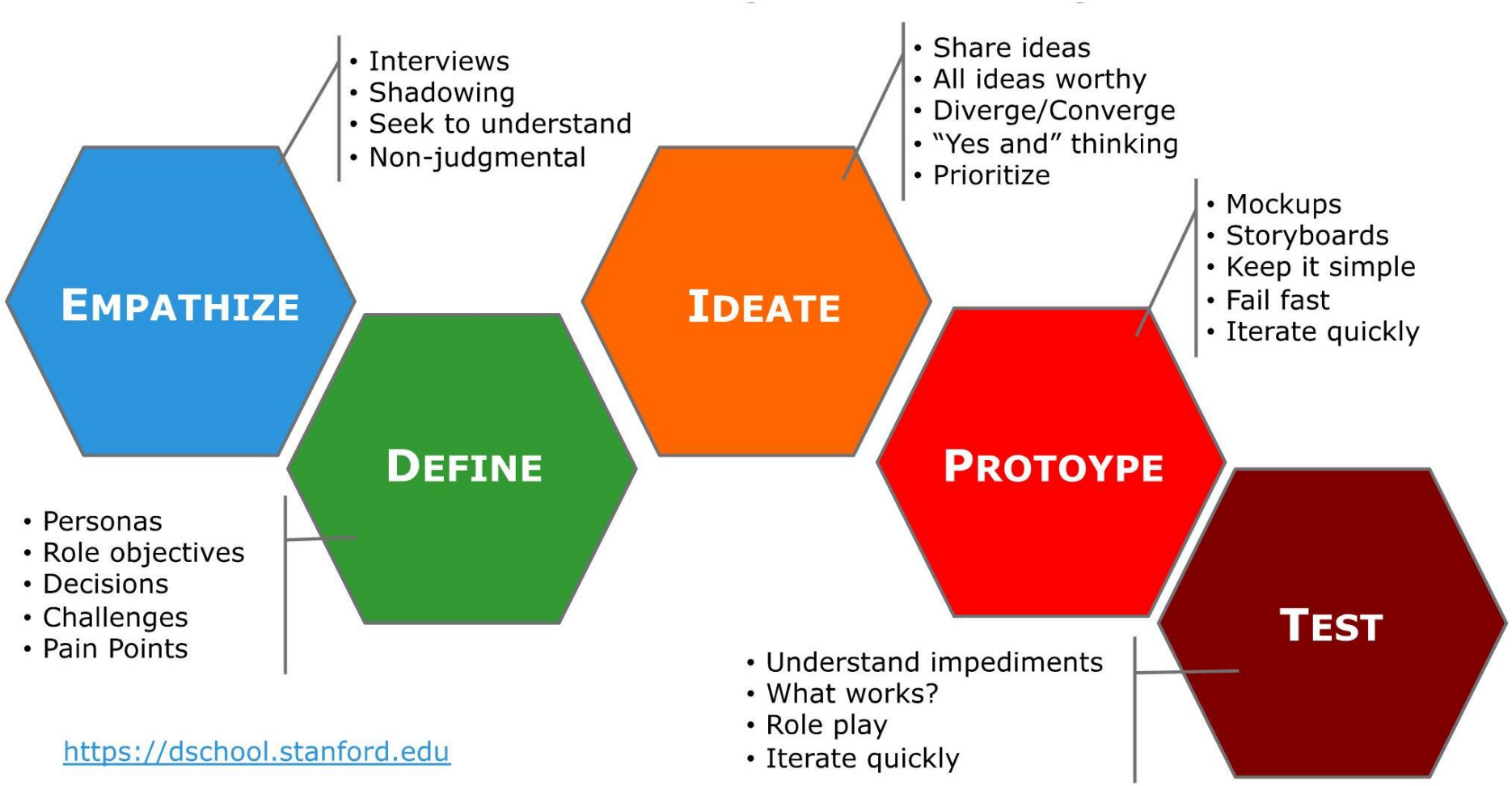


Companies like Apple have taken to using Design Thinking to assist them

Design Thinking Phases



Design thinking: Stanford model



https://dschool.stanford.edu

See: Sprouts (23 Oct 2017) '[The Design Thinking Process]'

Image [source]



Design thinking introduction video *(for you to review latter)*

Design thinking process

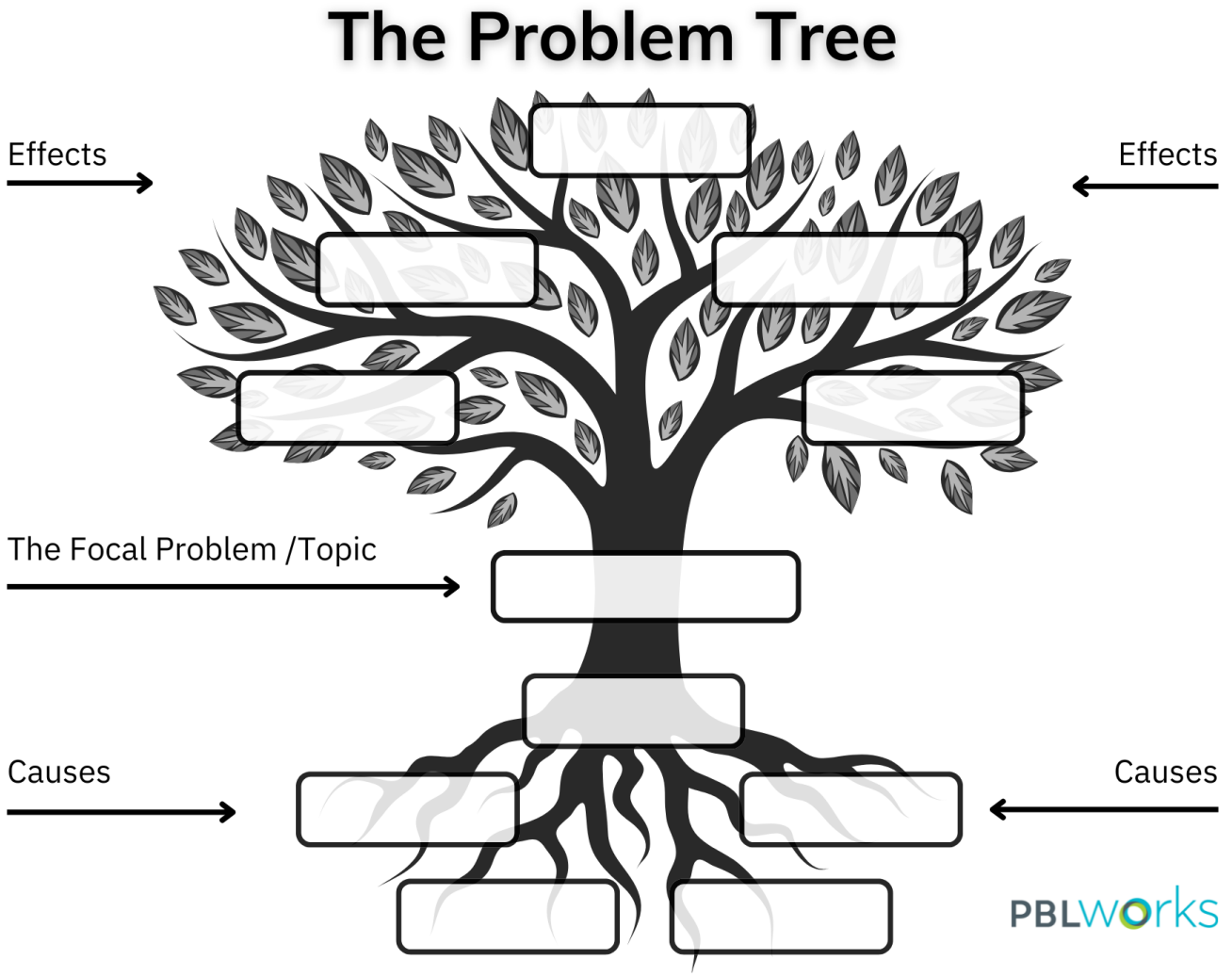
ACTIVITY 2 Empathy

Problem tree analysis

- Seek to understand
- Be open and no judgement

Ask questions like

- What are the effects of the problem?
- Which causes?



Problem Tree + AI?

AI makes it faster to generate, analyse the problem. It does not remove the need for empathy, context, YOUR judgement.

AI can accelerate	Humans must own	Leadership shift
Summarise anonymised inputs	Real stakeholder empathy	Problem-first
Generate alternative framings	Problem framing	not prompt-first
Expand idea variety	Evidence validation	AI options
Draft rough prototypes	Trade-offs, ethics and risk	not AI answers
Simulate challenge questions	Final decisions and accountability	Speed + learning
		not speed alone

Use AI to expand and challenge thinking—not to replace stakeholder contact or managerial judgement.

Empathy: Problem Tree + AI (if you want)

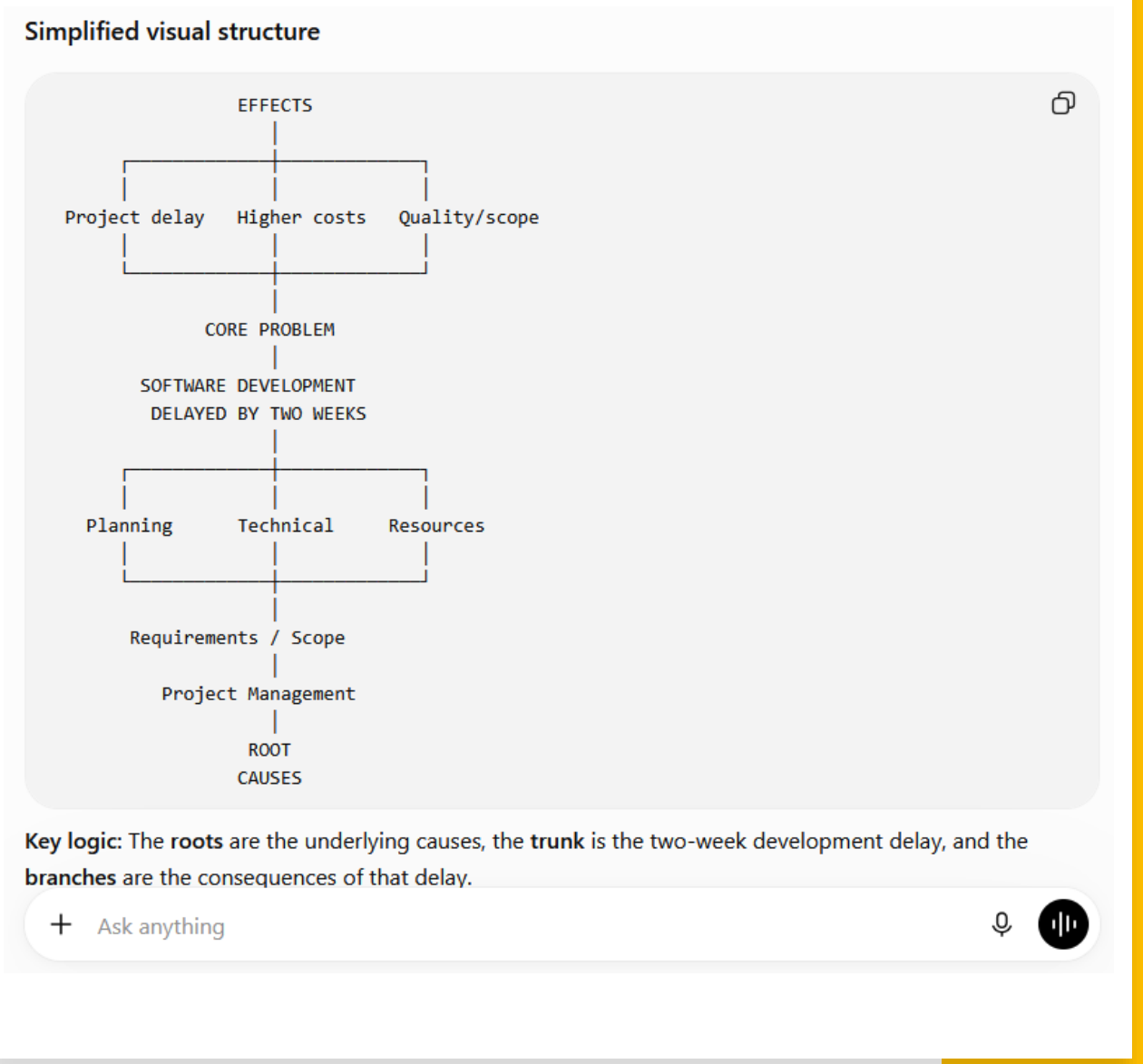
- Use Chat GPT/or other AI Chatbot

Prompt:

- Here is our core problem: <Add your team's problem>
- Develop the problem tree

Notes: The outcome will be general

Tips: Ask AI Chatbot to play a specific role, e.g. "Play the roles of a software developer team leader, develop the problem tree again"



AI-AUGMENTED

DESIGN THINKING FOR BLOCKERS

A human-centred, iterative process. AI can assist across the cycle, but people validate context, evidence, consequences and decisions.

1. EMPATHISE
Human first: understand real stakeholders. AI may summarise anonymised observations.

2. DEFINE
Humans frame the problem. AI may offer alternative framings to expose bias or blind spots.

3. IDEATE
Human ideas first. Then use AI to expand perspectives, contrasts and missing options.

4. PROTOTYPE
AI can accelerate rough workflows, scripts or mock-ups. Humans choose what to test.

5. TEST
Real people react. AI may organise feedback; humans judge impact, risk and next action.

Principle 1
Problem-first, not prompt-first.

Principle 2
Use only approved AI tools and non-confidential inputs.

ACTIVITY 3

STAKEHOLDER EMPATHY MAP

Table groups | 20 minutes

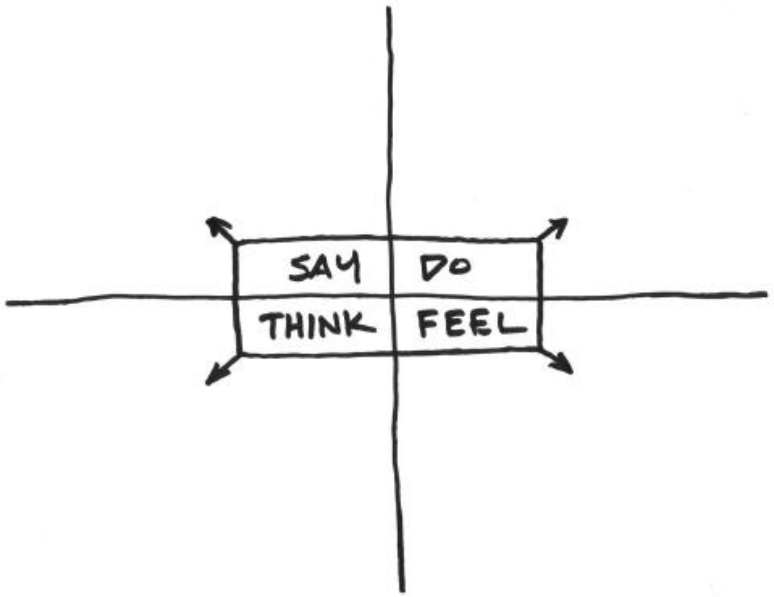
Understand one real stakeholder before your group defines the problem. AI does not substitute for empathy.

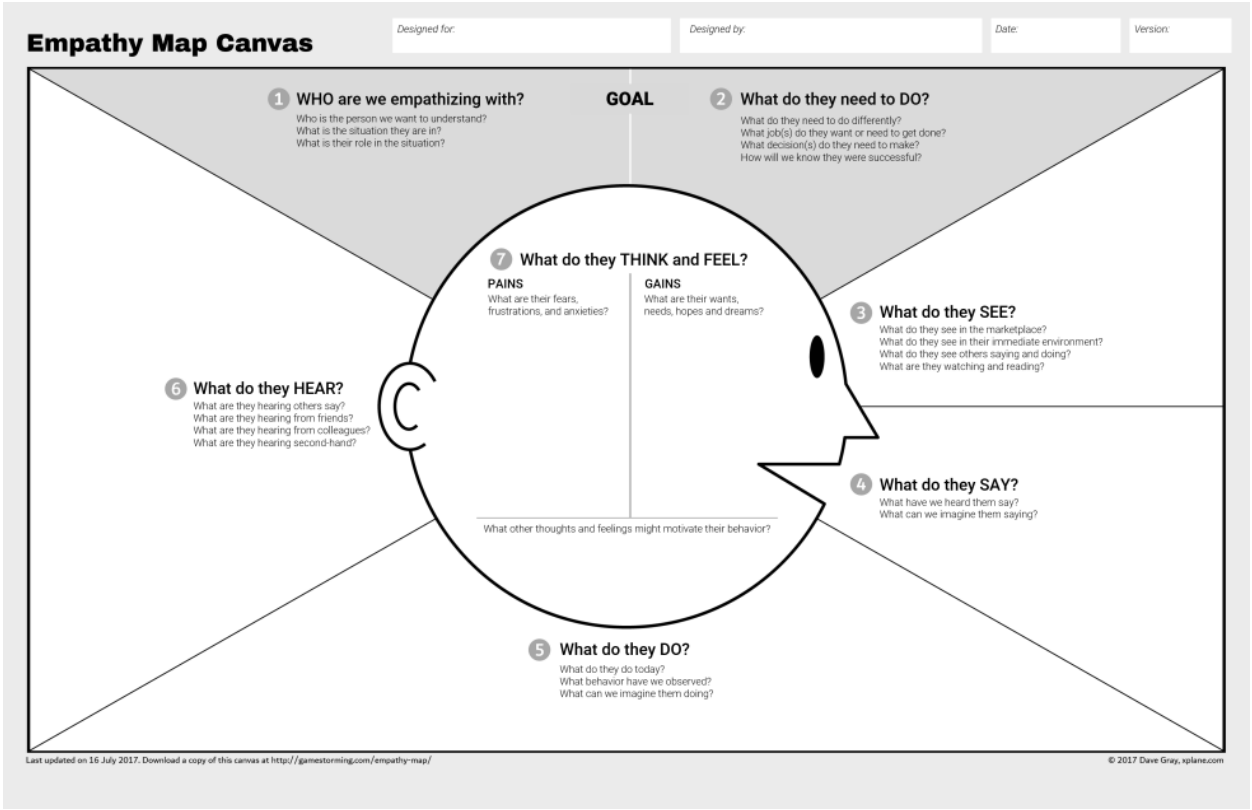
1. Select stakeholder	2. Map perspective	3. Name insight
- One member plays role of a key stakeholder - Interview the stakeholder OR - Choose one stakeholder/role that is centered to the problem: e.g. Product, Engineering, Project Manager, Senior Leader or Customer/Commercial.	Ask questions like - What are your challenges when doing X? - What are they trying to achieve - What they know or lack, and what they need. - How do you feel - What have you done/will you do	- Discuss these insights - Update your group's view of the blocker or the problem definition.

Group output: one empathy map + one insight. AI may later help summarise anonymised observations, but it must not invent stakeholder needs.

EMPATHY MAP

We have simple version (for the current activity), and more complete version: Empathy Map Canvas





- **Regardless the version, the key outcome is to understand the stakeholder and re-frame the problem**
- **Human-first rule: empathy comes from people and evidence. Use AI only later to organise anonymised observations – not to invent what a stakeholder thinks.**

DEFINE THE PROBLEM BEFORE YOU SOLVE

The interview/empathy map can help to separates symptoms, assumptions and causes.

Symptom
What we observe
“The release is delayed.”

Assumption
What we believe
“Engineering underestimated it.”

Possible cause
What may explain it
“Decision rights were unclear.”

A claim becomes useful only when the team can connect it to evidence and context

ACTIVITY 4: PROBLEM STATEMENT LAB

SIMPLE TEMPLATE

Table groups | 20 minutes

Turn the case from a symptoms into one shared, evidence-based group problem statement.

1. Write statement	2. Challenge it
Use the template: Stakeholder needs to ___ because ___ e.g (Recall the delay in launching the program, after the interview, we can formulate the problem statement) “Seng, the program manager, needs to discuss with Melbourne team because the course learning outcomes need to be specified"	Another group checks evidence, assumption and scope. Then, if an approved AI tool is available, ask for two alternative framings. Keep only what the evidence supports.

Group output: one revised, human-owned problem statement after peer + optional AI challenge.

PROBLEM STATEMENT

TEMPLATE

Use precise language that points to action without prescribing the solution too early.

Stakeholder	needs...	because...	resulting in...	evidence is...

Example

Product and engineering teams need earlier agreement on data requirements because late clarification creates repeated rework, resulting in sprint delays and quality defects. Evidence: three recent requirement changes and four repeated QA issues.

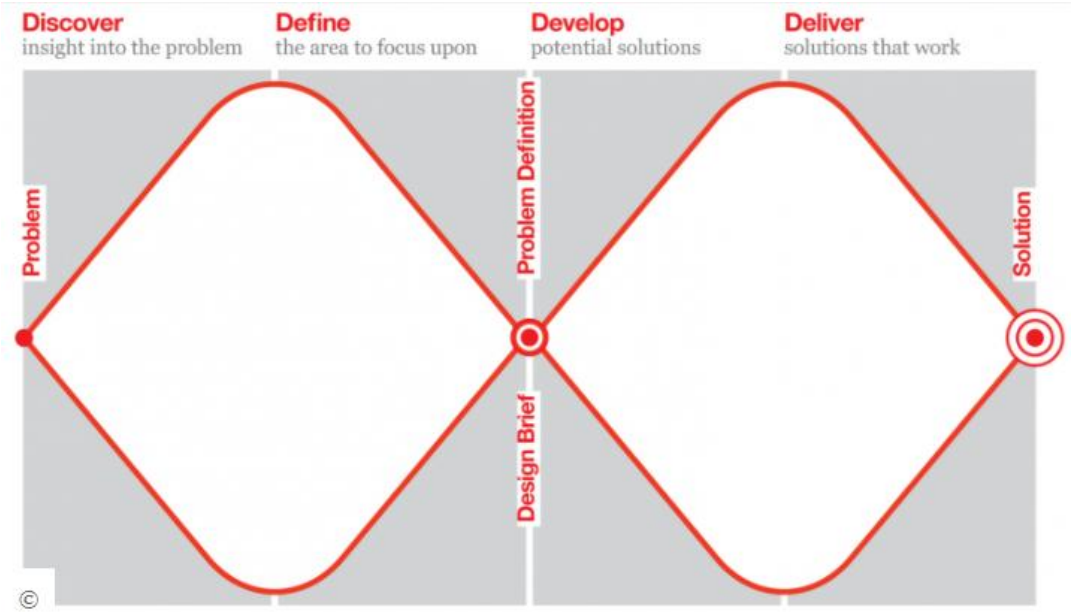
Better problem statements are specific, evidence-based and stakeholder-centred. AI can propose wording; the team remains responsible for whether the framing is true.

Problem reframe

ITERATIVE REFRAME

The problem statement can be reframed multiple time
It can be converted into a constructive design question that can guide ideation.

Good "How might we" questions are...	Weak	Stronger
• Human-centred • Focused • Open-ended • Actionable • Not already a solution	How might we make engineering move faster?	How might we clarify cross-functional requirements earlier so teams reduce rework and protect release quality?





Take a 15-Minute Break – You've Earned It.

RMIT UNIVERSITY

AFTER THE BREAK

FROM PROBLEM TO SOLUTION

Next step | Keep the same group

You already understand the problem. Now use that work to choose ONE simple action to try.

1. What you already have	2. What we do now	3. Where we finish
• Problem Tree • Stakeholder insight • Problem / HMW question	Think of a few possible solutions. Keep them connected to the problem you defined.	Choose ONE solution. Try it small. Decide the next step.

Keep your Problem Tree and HMW question on the table. Everything after the break starts from them.

ACTIVITY 5

FIND 3 POSSIBLE SOLUTIONS

Start with your problem / HMW question. Keep the activity simple.

1. Read the problem
Make sure everyone understands the same problem.

2. Everyone gives ideas
Each person gives 1–2 ideas. No judging yet.

3. AI is optional
Ask: “What one idea might we have missed?” Use safe information only.

4. Choose 3
Keep the three ideas that best help the problem you defined.

Group output: 3 possible solutions. Simple check: “Does this idea help the problem we defined?”

ACTIVITY 6

CHOOSE ONE SOLUTION

Look at your 3 ideas. Use four simple questions. Then choose ONE idea to try.

Group decision | 8 minutes

1. Helps the problem?

Does it address the main cause or need?

2. Can we try it soon?

Could we start within 7 days?

3. Can we influence it?

Is it mostly within our control?

4. Is the risk okay?

Is it safe enough to try on a small scale?

HOW TO CHOOSE

Put a ✓ next to each idea for every “Yes”.

Choose the idea with the strongest fit.

If two are close, vote as a group.

Group output: ONE solution to try. Be ready to say why you chose it.

SMALL TEST

NOT A PERFECT FINAL SOLUTION

A “prototype” simply means: try a small version first and learn from it.

Try a checklist
Use it for one task or one team.

Change one meeting
Try a new agenda or decision rule.

Change one handoff
Test a clearer step between two teams.

Use a simple template
Try it for one request or project.

Try with one team
Do not roll it out everywhere.

Try for one week
Check the result, then improve it.

Simple rule: Do not build the final solution. Test a small change and learn.

ACTIVITY 7

MAKE A 7-DAY TEST

Table groups | 15 minutes

Take the ONE solution you chose. Turn it into a small test your team could actually try.

1. What will we try?	2. Who + when?	3. What result?
Describe the small change in one simple sentence.	Who will do it? When will you start? Keep it small—one team or one week.	What should improve if the idea works? Choose ONE result you can see or measure.

Group output: one simple 7-day test — WHAT, WHO, WHEN and ONE RESULT.

7-DAY TEST

SIMPLE PLAN

Write short answers. One sentence in each box is enough.

Problem we are solving	**Small change we will try**	**Who will do it?**
When will we start?	**One result we expect**	**How will we check the result?**

Keep it small: ONE team • ONE week • ONE result to check.

ACTIVITY 8

ANOTHER GROUP CHECKS YOUR PLAN

Group exchange | 12 minutes

Keep the feedback simple. The goal is to make the plan easier to understand and easier to try.

1. Explain	2. Other group checks	3. Change one thing
Explain your 7-day test in ONE minute.	Answer 3 questions: • What is clear? • What may not work? • What is one suggestion?	The original group chooses ONE useful change and improves the plan.

Group output: one improved 7-day test plan.

WHAT HAPPENS NEXT?

Use what you learned to choose the next step. Keep the choice practical.

1 TRY IT	2 WORK TOGETHER	3 TEST FIRST	4 ASK MANAGER
Our team can do it.	We need another team.	We need a little more evidence.	We need a decision, resource or approval.

IF YOU NEED MANAGER HELP

1. The problem / result at risk	2. What we know or tried	3. What we need from you

A clear ask is better than a long explanation. Tell the manager the problem, what you know, and what help you need.

ACTIVITY 9

ASK FOR HELP CLEARLY

Pair practice | 10 minutes

Only do this if your solution needs a manager's decision, resource or approval.

1. Prepare 3 lines	2. Say it in 45 seconds	3. One question
• The problem is... • We know / tried... • We need you to...	One group speaks. The other group listens as the manager.	The "manager" asks: "What exactly do you need from me?" Then the group improves its ask.

Group output: one short, clear request for help.

SIMPLE

FEEDBACK CHECK

The listener only checks whether the message is easy to understand.

Problem is clear
Do I understand what is wrong?

Evidence is clear
Do I know what they know or tried?

Ask is clear
Do I know what help they need?

Feedback: “One thing that was clear was… One thing to make clearer is…”

OUR
7-DAY ACTION

Final group plan | 7 minutes

Look back at your Activity 7 plan (slide 29). Update it with what you learned — don't start from zero.

What will we change or add?
Based on the feedback from Activities 8 & 9.

Who else is needed?
Another team or manager, if any.

When will we review?
Agree a date to check the result.

Write one sentence: "By ___, ___ will ___, and we will check ___."

FROM PROBLEM

TO ACTION

The second half should feel simple: use the problem you defined, choose one action, test small, learn and move.

Strong leaders do not need the perfect answer. They understand the problem, choose a practical next step, learn from the result and ask for help clearly when needed.

OUR SIMPLE JOURNEY

1. Understand the problem
2. Understand the people
3. Find a few solutions
4. Choose one
5. Try it small
6. Learn and act

Final round: “Our problem is... Our 7-day action is... We will know it helped when...”

FACILITATOR REFERENCE

AI-AUGMENTED DESIGN THINKING

Use these current sources to understand the logic behind the session. They are background for the trainer, not required participant reading.

IDEO U — AI x Design Thinking Certificate (current)
Human-centred and AI-assisted methods: observation, synthesis, ideation, prototyping and responsible AI use.

IDEO — Design Thinking Process (current)
Design thinking is flexible and iterative: teams repeatedly create choices and make choices rather than follow a rigid linear checklist.

Stanford d.school — "Why AI Makes Design Skills More Valuable Than Ever" (2025)
AI can accelerate experimentation and option generation; curiosity, noticing, reflection and judgement remain critical human design skills.

Session rule of thumb
Human context first → AI expands or challenges → humans validate → real people test → leaders decide and own the consequences.

Important: follow Zalo/RMIT policy for approved AI tools and data handling. Never place confidential, personal or sensitive information into an unapproved AI service.

Thank you!

RMIT UNIVERSITY